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DATA SHEET

Irish Defence at a Glance: Q1 2026 Data Sheet

Key statistics on Irish defence spending, personnel, and capability development in the first quarter of 2026. This data sheet provides quick reference figures for analysis and policy discussion.

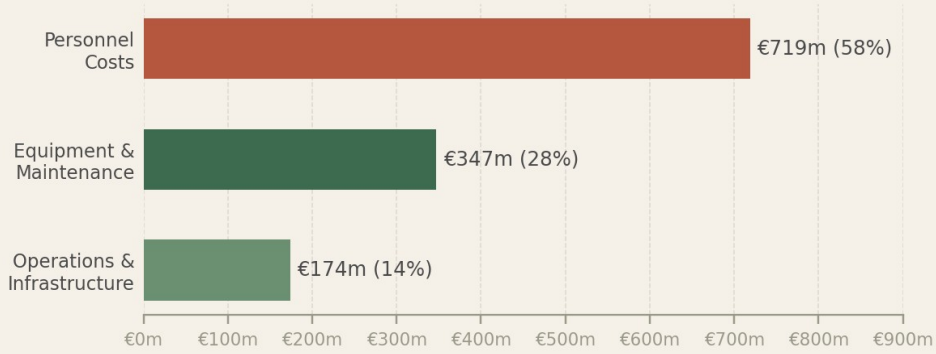
12 March 2026 · 3 min read

€1.24bn	7,650	625	12
2026 Defence Budget	Total Personnel	Deployed Overseas	PESCO Projects

Defence Budget and Spending

Ireland's total defence budget for 2026 stands at **€1.24 billion**, representing a year-on-year increase of **6.2%** compared to 2025. Personnel costs remain the dominant share at 58%, reflecting the labour-intensive nature of military operations. Equipment and maintenance account for 28%, while operations and infrastructure make up the remaining 14%.

Budget Allocation by Category, 2026



Source: Department of Defence, Revised Estimates 2026.

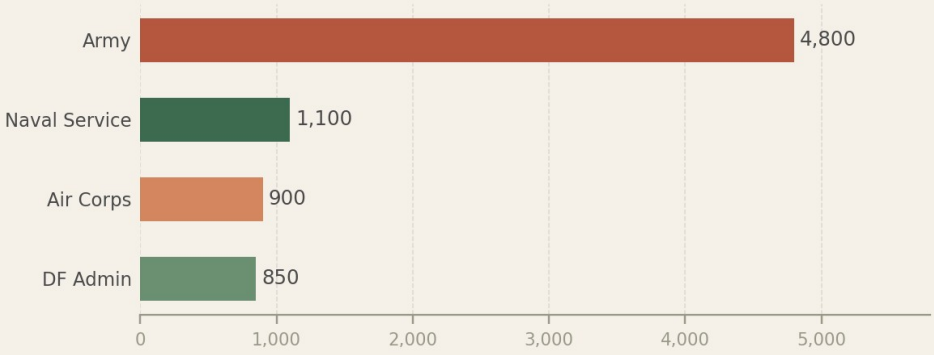
Category	Amount (€ millions)	Share
Personnel costs	€719m	58%
Equipment & maintenance	€347m	28%
Operations & infrastructure	€174m	14%
Total	**€1,240m**	**100%**

Source: Department of Defence, Revised Estimates 2026.

Personnel Strength

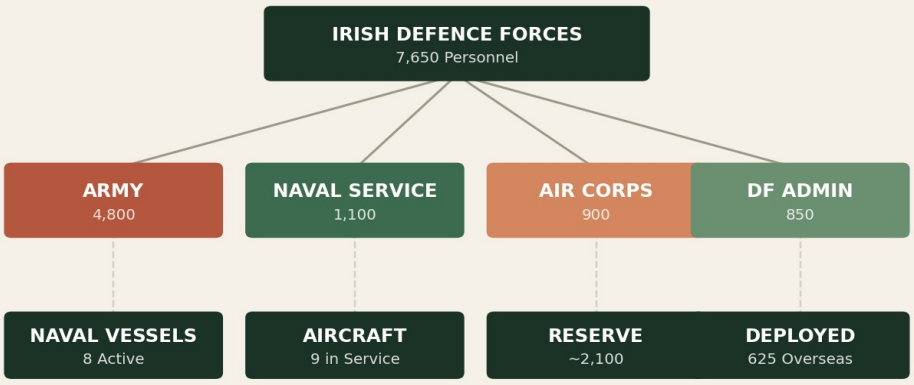
The Irish Defence Forces stood at **7,650 personnel** as of March 2026, comprising the Permanent Defence Force. An additional **~2,100 reservists** are mobilizable. The Army accounts for the largest share with 4,800 personnel, followed by the Naval Service (1,100), Air Corps (900), and Defence Forces administration (850).

Personnel by Service Branch



Source: Defence Forces Personnel Division, March 2026.

Defence Forces Structure and Key Capabilities



Defence Forces Structure & Key Capabilities — Q1 2026

Source: Security Ireland analysis based on Department of Defence data.

Naval Capabilities

The Naval Service operates **8 active vessels**: 2 Eithne-class offshore patrol vessels, 4 Oileán Gheálach-class coastal patrol vessels, and 2 inshore patrol craft. Extended maritime surveillance and offshore patrol capacity remain the key capability gaps.

Vessel Type	Class	Number
Offshore patrol vessels	Eithne-class	2
Coastal patrol vessels	Oileán Gheálach-class	4
Inshore patrol craft	—	2
Total		**8**

Source: Naval Service operational records, Q1 2026.

KEY CAPABILITY GAP

> Extended maritime surveillance and offshore patrol capacity remain critical shortfalls. Ireland's maritime domain of 880,000 km² is among the largest in Europe, yet the Naval Service operates with fewer vessels than many comparable nations.

Air Capabilities

The Air Corps maintains **9 aircraft in service**: 5 Cessna 206 light aircraft for patrol, 2 Sikorsky S-61 helicopters for transport and search-and-rescue, and 2 BN2 Islander light aircraft for patrol. A procurement process for new medium-lift helicopter capability is currently ongoing.

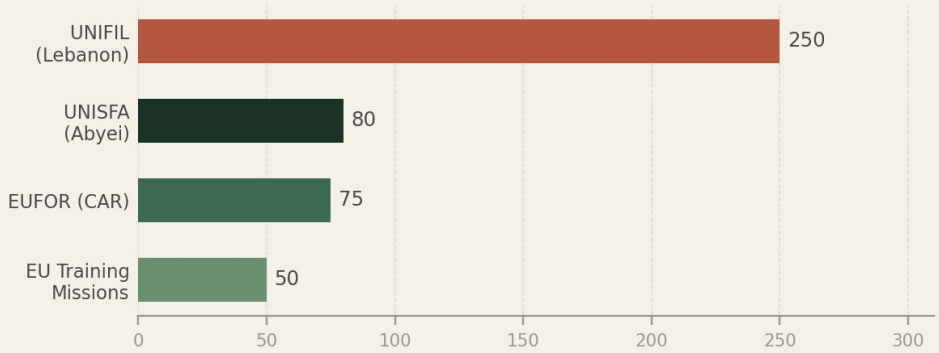
Aircraft Type	Role	Number
Cessna 206	Light patrol	5
Sikorsky S-61	Transport / SAR	2
BN2 Islander	Light patrol	2
Total		**9**

Source: Air Corps fleet records, Q1 2026.

International Operations and Commitments

Ireland had **625 personnel deployed overseas** in Q1 2026 across United Nations missions (425), EU missions (125), and other bilateral operations (75). The largest single deployment is UNIFIL in Lebanon with 250 personnel.

Personnel Deployed by Mission, Q1 2026



Source: Defence Forces overseas operations reports, Q1 2026.

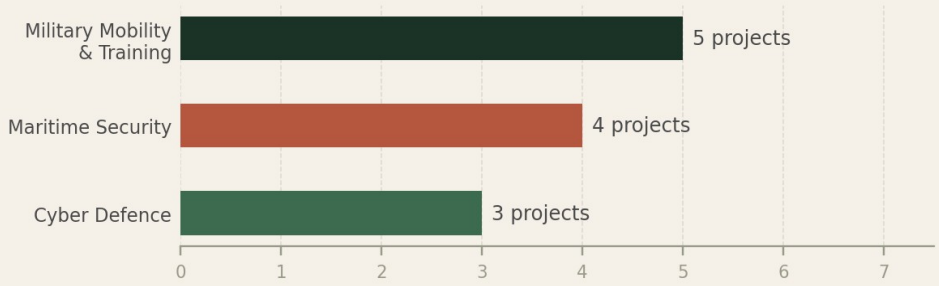
Mission	Type	Personnel
UNIFIL (Lebanon)	United Nations	250
UNISFA (Abyei)	United Nations	80
EUFOR (Central African Republic)	European Union	75
EU Training Missions	European Union	50
Other UN missions	United Nations	95
Other bilateral operations	Bilateral	75
Total		**625**

Source: Defence Forces overseas operations reports, Q1 2026.

PESCO Participation

Ireland participates in **12 active PESCO projects** as of March 2026, spanning three key domains: military mobility and training (5 projects), maritime security (4 projects), and cyber defence (3 projects).

PESCO Projects by Domain

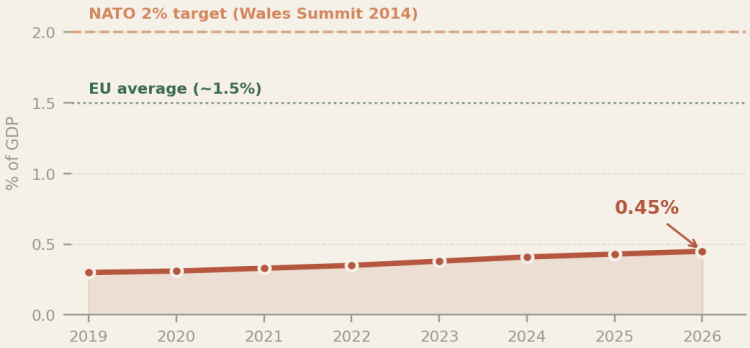


Source: EU PESCO Secretariat, March 2026.

Defence Spending Trends

Ireland's defence spending has increased steadily in recent years, reflecting recognition of evolving security challenges. However, at approximately **0.45% of GDP**, Irish defence spending remains well below NATO's 2% benchmark and below the EU average of approximately 1.5%. The trend line below illustrates the trajectory since 2019.

Irish Defence Spending as % of GDP, 2019–2026



NATO 2% TARGET

Formalised at the 2014 Wales Summit as a non-binding political commitment. The target measures financial inputs (GDP share) rather than capability outputs. A 3% target for 2035 is now under discussion. Ireland, as a non-NATO member, is not bound by this benchmark but it is widely used as a comparative reference point.

EU AVERAGE (~1.5%)

The EU27 weighted average defence spending stands at roughly 1.5% of GDP, although this figure is heavily skewed by larger member states. The Stability and Growth Pact now includes an escape clause allowing up to 1.5% of GDP in additional defence spending without triggering excessive deficit procedures (2025–2028).

Source: Department of Defence Annual Reports; SIPRI Military Expenditure Database; Security Ireland estimates for 2025–2026.

CONTEXT

At 0.45% of GDP, Ireland spends less on defence as a share of national income than any EU member state except Malta. The Commission on the Defence Forces (2022) recommended reaching a minimum spending level to address critical capability gaps across maritime surveillance, air defence, and cyber security.

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